

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with practical experience in client-facing legal roles, case and file management, and document review. At Citizens Advice East Berkshire I am the first point of contact for clients across a range of legal matters, managing cases from initial instruction through to completion. My year at BCLP (international arbitration and real estate disputes) developed skills in deadline management, electronic file organisation and hearing preparation. Additional experience reviewing commercial contracts and data-processing provisions at Adobe. Strong written and verbal communication skills, comfortable handling high volumes of work and competing deadlines.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit **Sept 2024 – Oct 2025**

Queen Mary University of London

- Modules in international arbitration, dispute resolution, legal research and evidence analysis
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (data privacy and democracy) — 75%
- Dissertation: data protection and the development of GDPR across jurisdictions

Law LLB — 2:1

Sept 2020 – June 2024

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme of Law and International Relations

Sept 2019 – June 2020

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of a 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead

July 2026 – Present

Legal Adviser

- First point of contact for clients across welfare benefits, employment, housing, family, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed instructions and establishes the key legal and evidential issues from the outset
- Manages matters from initial enquiry through to completion: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Advises clients on procedural requirements and options, translating complex rules into clear, practical guidance for people who are often under financial or personal pressure
- Assesses eligibility against statutory criteria, identifies evidential gaps and researches complex points where needed

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London

Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial
- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant procedural deadline; coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and helped ensure on-time submission
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines throughout the matter
- Liaised with the client on required documents; coordinated Romanian translations with an external translator
- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London

Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Prepared electronic hearing bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and other court materials
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Maintained matter records on iManage; assisted with court filings, hearing arrangements and deadline tracking across several concurrent matters
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents with competing deadlines; prepared client notes and cost comparisons

Q-Legal · London

Oct 2024 – Jan 2025

Legal Adviser

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to a formal written advice letter, under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations for a data-driven start-up, including children's personal data and adtech
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with the client and supervising solicitor to meet the deadline

Adobe · London

June 2022 – Aug 2022

Legal Intern

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with Adobe's internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border personal data transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries and reconcile commercial objectives with legal risk
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems; document review

Case and evidence management: Client onboarding and instruction-taking; case-file organisation and maintenance; deadline tracking; hearing bundle preparation; procedural histories; evidence review